

Microsoft Advertising Blueprint Framework

Building always-on accounts, with
growth focus on PMax and
Audience Advertising



AUDIENCES YOU CAN'T
FIND ANYWHERE ELSE

Reach your customers

with engaging ads
where they work,
browse, and play.



Connect with
people across
work and life

On sites they
visit every day

As they're
shopping

As they're
watching

As they're
gaming

As they're
browsing

Microsoft Advertising Vertical Blueprints

Practical, always-on account buildouts from Search to Performance Max, Audience Ads, and remarketing

Select the right build based on vertical, advertiser goal, gap analysis, and blocker.

Search

Capture intent

Shopping

Product demand

Performance Max

Automate conversion

Audience Ads

Create demand

Remarketing

Reconnect interest

Choose the relevant campaign option or mix. These are complementary choices, not a fixed sequence.

Four inputs decide the recommended build

Use the four inputs to choose the next build, then agree accountability and timing.

1 Select the vertical

2 Confirm the primary goal

3 Run a gap analysis

4 Identify the main blocker

Vertical

- Travel
- Retail and ecommerce
- B2B
- Careers and education
- Health and wellness
- Financial services
- Gambling and betting
- Dating
- Automotive
- Real estate and property
- Home services and local trades
- SaaS and technology

Goal

- Brand awareness
- Engagement and site traffic
- Leads or bookings
- Sales and ROAS
- Remarketing and customer recovery

Gap analysis

- What is live today?
- Which goal lacks coverage?
- Are tracking and feeds ready?
- Which campaign fills the gap?
- Select one next build

Blocker

- Poor performance
- Budget constraints
- Tracking or feed readiness
- Limited creative
- Existing programmatic investment
- Limited internal capability

Agree the next build. Who owns the first action? When will it launch, and on what date will we review the agreed KPI?

Match the campaign mix to the goal, then agree the measures first

Agree the campaign mix, success measures and tracking dependencies before launch. IBR = impression-based remarketing.

ADVERTISER GOAL	START WITH	ADD NEXT	MEASURE	TRACKING / DEPENDENCIES
Brand awareness	Audience image, video, display, native or premium streaming	Collect IBR from Audience impressions. Activate in a dedicated Audience remarketing campaign.	Reach, impressions, video completion, engaged visits	Native reach/video reports. Analytics for engaged visits. IBR collects ad impressions.
Engagement and site traffic	Targeted Audience Ads	Website remarketing and relevant Search coverage	CTR, landing-page activity, engaged visits, site visitation	UET + consent for site lists. Analytics events for engagement.
Leads or bookings	Strong Search foundations	Performance Max plus separate Audience prospecting and remarketing	Qualified leads, bookings, conversion rate, CPA	UET conversion goals. Booking/CRM access for qualified outcomes and offline imports.
Retail sales and ROAS	Search and Shopping with a healthy product feed	Feed-based Performance Max, then Dynamic Remarketing and Audience Ads	Revenue, sales, ROAS, average order value	UET purchase goal + variable revenue/currency. Merchant Center feed. Developer access.
Customer recovery	Website or Dynamic Remarketing	Build IBR from Audience impressions. Reuse or create an Audience remarketing campaign.	Returning conversions, CPA, recovered revenue, ROAS	UET + consent for site lists. Dynamic remarketing product IDs/feed. Revenue for ROAS.

IBR: collect with Audience, then reuse/create dedicated Audience remarketing. Assign website, analytics and feed access owners.

Build to an always-on account in four stages, and review every thirty days

Each stage protects what already works before adding the next layer, and every layer stays live once it is on.

STAGE 1 Foundation

- Confirm UET tracking, the Universal Event Tracking tag, and conversion tracking
- Separate Brand and Generic Search where appropriate
- Review budgets, landing pages, feed quality, and extensions
- Build core website visitor and converting-user lists

STAGE 2 Expand performance

- Launch PMax for the primary conversion or value goal
- Group related products or services with matching assets and landing pages, e.g. hiking boots
- Seed signals with relevant customers, site visitors and in-market audiences
- Keep proven Search and Shopping live

STAGE 3 Create demand

- Launch targeted Audience Ads
- Separate prospecting and remarketing
- Align creative and messaging with funnel stage
- Create impression-based remarketing lists

STAGE 4 Scale and measure

- Expand winning products, audiences or messages
- Use sequential messaging
- Log launch status, completed actions, tracking checks and KPI changes
- Assign owners to blockers and review every 30 days

Proposed gate: meet the agreed CPA/ROAS for two comparable weeks after conversion lag, with reliable tracking and an agreed minimum conversion volume. Set the volume per account. Review every 30 days.



Travel: protect booking intent, then create destination demand

Build from booking intent outward to seasonal and destination-led demand creation.

TYPICAL GOALS

Bookings

Destination awareness

Qualified visits

Seasonal demand

ACCOUNT BUILDOUT

1 Protect Brand, destination, and high-intent Search

2 Confirm booking tracking and revenue values

3 Launch Performance Max using destination, property, or experience-based asset groups

4 Launch one focused Audience Ads campaign around a destination, season, or travel motivation

5 Build destination-page, property-page, and booking-start audiences

6 Build IBR from step 4 Audience ads. Activate in an existing/new Audience remarketing campaign.

7 Introduce return-to-book messaging

8 Scale the destinations and creative themes that generate qualified interest

RECOMMENDED AUDIENCES

- Destination and property page visitors
- Booking-start and abandoned-booking users
- In-market travel and impression-based pools

SUCCESS MEASURES

- Bookings and booking value
- Qualified visits and engaged sessions
- Cost per booking and return on ad spend

COMMON WATCHOUTS

- Seasonality shifts demand quickly
- Thin booking tracking limits automation
- Upper-funnel activity judged on Brand Search CPA

Takeaway: Protect booking intent first, then create demand for the destinations you want to fill.



Retail: fix feed and tracking, then automate and recover demand

Commercial structure and clean data decide how far automation can scale.

TYPICAL GOALS

Product sales

Revenue

ROAS

New customers

Average order value

ACCOUNT BUILDOUT

1 Confirm purchase tracking, conversion value, feed health, and Merchant Center readiness

2 Protect high-performing Search and Shopping activity

3 Link the Merchant Center feed to PMax. Group feed products by category, margin or stock priority.

4 Retain Standard Shopping where additional product control is required

5 Launch Dynamic Remarketing for product viewers and cart abandoners

6 Use Audience Ads for category discovery, seasonal demand, and customer acquisition

7 Build impression-based remarketing pools

8 Scale based on margin, inventory, revenue, and ROAS

RECOMMENDED AUDIENCES

- Product viewers and cart abandoners
- Category and seasonal in-market shoppers
- Impression-based and past-purchaser pools

SUCCESS MEASURES

- Revenue and conversion value
- ROAS and average order value
- New customer share

COMMON WATCHOUTS

- Feed errors cap Performance Max delivery
- Too many fragmented product groups
- Budget spread across every category at once

Takeaway: Feed health and purchase tracking decide how far Performance Max can scale.



B2B: qualify the conversion before you automate against it

Automation only helps when the conversion action reflects real pipeline quality.

TYPICAL GOALS

Qualified leads

Account engagement

Pipeline

Content consumption

ACCOUNT BUILDOUT

1 Confirm lead quality and qualified conversion actions

2 Protect Brand, category, competitor, and high-intent Search

3 Use Performance Max where qualified conversion volume supports automation

4 Launch Audience Ads with relevant in-market segments as Target and bid. Keep remarketing separate.

5 Layer LinkedIn company, industry or job-function segments as Bid only. Test positive bid adjustments.

6 Build content-viewer, high-value-page, and lead-form remarketing lists

7 Build IBR from step 4 Audience ads. Activate in an existing/new Audience remarketing campaign.

8 Use sequential messages from education to proof point to conversion

RECOMMENDED AUDIENCES

- Professional profile signals by role and industry
- Content viewers and high-value page visitors
- Lead-form starters and impression-based pools

SUCCESS MEASURES

- Qualified leads and lead quality rate
- Pipeline contribution
- Cost per qualified lead

COMMON WATCHOUTS

- Do not optimize toward weak or unqualified lead actions
- Low conversion volume limits automation
- Single message for every decision stage

Takeaway: Define the qualified conversion first, because automation will scale whatever you point it at.



Careers and education: guide discovery to completed applications

Long consideration cycles reward sequenced messaging and clean stage tracking.

TYPICAL GOALS

Applications

Registrations

Course discovery

Qualified engagement

ACCOUNT BUILDOUT

1 Confirm application, registration, and course-interest tracking

2 Protect program, qualification, institution, and Brand Search

3 Use Performance Max for completed applications or registrations

4 Test course-relevant in-market audiences where available. Use program-specific creative to qualify interest.

5 Use consented course-interest signals where policy permits. Avoid demographic proxies for students.

6 Build course-viewer, event-attendee, and application-start audiences

7 Build IBR from step 4 Audience ads. Activate in an existing/new Audience remarketing campaign.

8 Sequence messages from discovery to program benefit to application deadline

RECOMMENDED AUDIENCES

- Course viewers and prospectus requesters
- Open day and event attendees
- Application starters, where policy permits

SUCCESS MEASURES

- Applications and registrations
- Application completion rate
- Cost per application and qualified engagement

COMMON WATCHOUTS

- Intake deadlines compress the cycle
- Course-interest tracking often incomplete
- Check education/employment targeting policy

Takeaway: Track every stage from course view to application start, then sequence the message to the deadline.



Health and wellness: build within compliance, then scale to capacity

Policy readiness and service capacity set the limits of the build.

TYPICAL GOALS

Appointments

Consultations

Registrations

Awareness

Qualified visits

ACCOUNT BUILDOUT

1 Confirm compliant tracking and landing-page readiness

2 Protect Brand, service, location, and high-intent Search

3 Use Performance Max for measurable appointment or lead outcomes

4 Use Audience Ads for service education and awareness

5 Use only policy-permitted audiences. Avoid sensitive health interests or inferred conditions.

6 Check policy before creating visitor lists. Exclude sensitive treatment or appointment signals.

7 If policy permits, build IBR from step 4. Activate in an existing/new Audience remarketing campaign.

8 Scale only messages supported by policy, performance, and business capacity

RECOMMENDED AUDIENCES

- Only policy-permitted, non-sensitive audiences
- Consent alone does not permit health targeting
- Use broad service education when lists are restricted

SUCCESS MEASURES

- Appointments and consultations booked
- Qualified visits and enquiry rate
- Cost per appointment

COMMON WATCHOUTS

- Policy, consent and landing-page claims
- Small service radii can restrict delivery
- Broaden only within the real service area
- Match demand to appointment capacity

Takeaway: Compliance and capacity, not budget, usually set the ceiling on health and wellness growth.



Financial services: optimize toward qualified outcomes, not volume

Compliance, consent, and conversion value definitions come before any scale decision.

TYPICAL GOALS

Qualified leads

Applications

Consultations

Brand trust

Customer acquisition

ACCOUNT BUILDOUT

1 Confirm conversion definitions, compliance, consent, and value

2 Protect Brand, product, service, and high-intent Search

3 Use Performance Max for qualified applications or validated leads

4 Use Audience Ads to introduce products and create demand

5 Use professional, in-market, and relevant customer signals

6 Build product-page and application-start remarketing lists

7 Build IBR from step 4 if policy permits. Reuse/create Audience remarketing for sequenced education.

8 Optimize toward qualified business outcomes rather than raw lead volume

RECOMMENDED AUDIENCES

- Product-page visitors and calculator users
- Application starters and drop-offs
- Professional, in-market, and impression-based pools

SUCCESS MEASURES

- Validated applications and qualified leads
- Approval or acceptance rate
- Cost per funded or qualified outcome

COMMON WATCHOUTS

- Consent and compliance constraints on data
- Unvalidated leads inflate apparent performance
- Complex products need education before conversion

Takeaway: Point automation at validated outcomes so the account scales quality rather than volume.



Gambling and betting: build inside licensing rules, then optimize to player value

Certification, geo-targeting, and responsible-gambling controls come before any scale decision.

TYPICAL GOALS

First-time deposits

Registrations

App installs

Player retention

Responsible play

ACCOUNT BUILDOUT

1 Confirm licences, ad certification, and permitted geographies per market

2 Protect brand, operator, and high-intent sports and casino Search terms

3 Use Performance Max for verified registrations and first-time deposits

4 Use Audience Ads around events and seasonal betting moments

5 Apply in-market, sports-interest, and exclusion signals for restricted users

6 Build registration-start and deposit drop-off remarketing lists

7 Add impression-based remarketing, then app-install and reactivation journeys

8 Optimize toward deposit value and retained players, not sign-up volume

RECOMMENDED AUDIENCES

- Registration starters and deposit drop-offs
- Sports and casino in-market and impression-based pools
- Existing players for cross-product and reactivation

SUCCESS MEASURES

- Verified registrations and first-time deposits
- Deposit value and retention rate
- Cost per funded, retained player

COMMON WATCHOUTS

- Certification and geo rules differ by market
- Sign-up volume overstates value without deposits
- Responsible-gambling exclusions must be enforced

Takeaway: Compliance sets the boundaries; optimize inside them toward depositing, retained players.



Dating: earn trust in the creative, then optimize to paying subscribers

Policy and brand-safety checks come first; value sits in retained, paying members, not raw sign-ups.

TYPICAL GOALS

App installs

Free sign-ups

Paid subscriptions

Profile
completion

Member retention

ACCOUNT BUILDOUT

1 Confirm dating-category policy, age-gating, and permitted markets before launch

2 Protect brand and competitor-conquest Search terms across app and web

3 Use Performance Max for completed sign-ups and paid subscription starts

4 Use Audience Ads for discovery around peak dating moments such as January and holidays

5 Apply in-market, life-stage, and interest signals; exclude existing members

6 Build remarketing for sign-up starters and profile abandoners

7 Add impression-based remarketing and reactivation journeys for lapsed members

8 Optimize toward subscription value and retained members, not sign-up volume

RECOMMENDED AUDIENCES

- Sign-up starters and profile abandoners
- In-market, life-stage, and impression-based pools
- Lapsed members for reactivation and win-back

SUCCESS MEASURES

- Completed sign-ups and paid subscription starts
- Subscription value and 30-day retention
- Cost per paying, retained member

COMMON WATCHOUTS

- Policy and age-gating rules differ by market
- Free sign-ups overstate value without subscriptions
- Creative fatigue is fast in a crowded category

Takeaway: Win trust in the creative, then optimize to paying, retained members - not free sign-ups.



Automotive: capture model demand, then convert it to dealer-ready leads

Long consideration cycles mean demand creation and remarketing matter as much as bottom-funnel Search.

TYPICAL GOALS

Test drives

Dealer leads

Locator visits

Brochure
requests

Model awareness

ACCOUNT BUILDOUT

- 1 Split OEM brand, model, and dealer-location Search terms
- 2 Track test-drive, enquiry, and locator actions as distinct conversions
- 3 Use Performance Max against dealer-ready enquiries once tracking is clean
- 4 Use Audience Ads for model launches, offers, and in-market consideration
- 5 Apply in-market auto, life-stage, and competitor-consideration signals
- 6 Remarket configurator and model-page visitors, and add impression-based remarketing
- 7 Add geo and radius controls so dealer budgets stay in their territory
- 8 Optimize toward qualified dealer leads, not raw form volume

RECOMMENDED AUDIENCES

- Configurator and model-page visitors
- In-market auto, finance, and impression-based pools
- Existing owners for service and upgrade cycles

SUCCESS MEASURES

- Test drives and dealer-ready enquiries
- Locator and configurator completions
- Cost per qualified dealer lead

COMMON WATCHOUTS

- Long cycles hide value in short CPA windows
- Dealer and OEM budgets overlap on the same terms
- Stock and offer changes date creative quickly

Takeaway: Create model demand early, then measure on dealer-ready enquiries, not clicks.



Real estate and property: capture local intent, then nurture the long decision

High-value, low-frequency decisions reward local precision and sustained remarketing.

TYPICAL GOALS

Viewing requests

Valuation leads

Listing alerts

Enquiries

Developer sign-ups

ACCOUNT BUILDOUT

1 Structure Search by location, property type, and buy versus rent intent

2 Track viewings, valuations, and listing-alert sign-ups as separate conversions

3 Use Performance Max for enquiry and valuation volume once lead quality is defined

4 Use Audience Ads to build development and area awareness ahead of launch

5 Apply in-market property, mover, and life-stage signals by radius

6 Remarket listing and saved-search visitors with matching property types

7 Add impression-based and feed-driven dynamic remarketing across the long decision

8 Optimize toward booked viewings and qualified valuations, not enquiry count

RECOMMENDED AUDIENCES

- Listing and saved-search visitors
- In-market movers, first-time buyers, and impression-based pools
- Past enquirers for new launches in the same area

SUCCESS MEASURES

- Booked viewings and completed valuations
- Qualified enquiries by location
- Cost per qualified enquiry

COMMON WATCHOUTS

- Inventory changes faster than creative
- Broad geo targeting wastes spend in property
- Enquiry volume rarely equals buyer intent

Takeaway: Win the local intent, then keep the advertiser present across a long decision.



Home services and local trades: win the urgent local job, then build repeat demand

Small budgets and urgent intent mean tight geography, calls, and hours matter more than scale.

TYPICAL GOALS

Calls

Booked jobs

Quote requests

Local visits

Repeat customers

ACCOUNT BUILDOUT

1 Confirm call tracking, forms, and booking actions before adding any budget

2 Concentrate Search on the highest-value services and tightest service radius

3 Use Performance Max for booked jobs once call and form tracking is reliable

4 Use Audience Ads for seasonal and preventative-service demand

5 Apply hours, day-parting, and radius controls to match crew capacity

6 Remarket quote-request abandoners with the same service message

7 Add local extensions, reviews, and clear pricing signals to creative

8 Optimize toward booked jobs and call quality, not click volume

RECOMMENDED AUDIENCES

- Quote-request abandoners
- In-market home-improvement and mover pools
- Past customers for seasonal and repeat services

SUCCESS MEASURES

- Booked jobs and answered calls
- Quote-to-job conversion rate
- Cost per booked job

COMMON WATCHOUTS

- Small budgets spread across too many services
- Missed calls destroy measured performance
- Capacity limits make scale the wrong goal

Takeaway: Concentrate spend on the highest-value jobs inside the real service radius.



SaaS and technology: automate against qualified pipeline, not trial sign-ups

Self-serve and enterprise motions need different conversions, and both need lead quality defined first.

TYPICAL GOALS

Free trials

Demo requests

Pipeline

Product sign-ups

Expansion

ACCOUNT BUILDOUT

1 Separate self-serve trial and enterprise demo motions in the account

2 Define the qualified conversion with sales before automating against it

3 Import offline qualification or pipeline signals back into the account

4 Use Performance Max for trial starts and demo requests once quality is defined

5 Use Audience Ads for category and problem-aware demand creation

6 Apply job-function, industry, and company-size signals where available

7 Remarket pricing, docs, and trial-abandon visitors; add impression-based remarketing

8 Optimize toward qualified pipeline and retained accounts, not raw sign-ups

RECOMMENDED AUDIENCES

- Pricing, documentation, and impression-based pools
- Trial starters who did not activate
- Existing customers for expansion and cross-sell

SUCCESS MEASURES

- Qualified demos and pipeline created
- Trial-to-paid conversion rate
- Cost per qualified opportunity

COMMON WATCHOUTS

- Trial volume overstates value without activation
- Long sales cycles need offline conversion import
- Self-serve and enterprise goals conflict in one campaign

Takeaway: Feed the account real qualification signals, then let automation chase pipeline.

Poor performance: work the diagnostic in order before changing the build

Check foundations first. Change one material element at a time.

1

Is tracking reliable?

2

Is the campaign budget restricted?

3

Is there sufficient conversion evidence?

4

Are bids or audience settings too restrictive?

5

Is the campaign structure too fragmented?

6

Are audiences, creative, feed, and landing pages aligned?

THEN CHOOSE ONE ACTION

Fix the foundation

Tracking, budgets, feed, and landing pages before any new campaign.

Simplify and relearn

Consolidate structure, relax restrictive bids or audiences, and allow a stable test period.

Scale only proven elements

Expand the products, audiences, and messages with evidence behind them.

Measurement note

Upper-funnel Audience Ads should not be evaluated only against Brand Search cost per acquisition. Judge demand creation on reach, engagement, and later conversion activity across Search, Shopping, and Performance Max.

Budget constraints: concentrate the spend rather than spreading it

Protect what works, prioritize what adds value, and simplify everything else.

Protect

- Proven Brand Search
- Commercially critical Search or Shopping
- Reliable conversion tracking

Prioritize

- Performance Max for automated conversions or value
- Audience Ads for incremental reach and targeted demand
- Remarketing for known demand
- Shopping for product control

Simplify

- One product or service theme with aligned messaging
- Fewer audiences and asset groups
- Stable test period
- One material change at a time

Principle

Do not spread a limited budget across too many campaigns, audiences, products, or objectives.

Microsoft Audience Ads and programmatic solve different planning needs

How Microsoft Audience Ads can complement your existing programmatic investment.

Microsoft Audience Ads

- Connects Microsoft Search intent with Audience activation
- Uses Microsoft audience and professional signals
- Creates impression-based remarketing lists
- Coordinates Audience, Search, Shopping, and Performance Max activity
- Supports targeted campaigns managed in the Microsoft Advertising platform
- Provides a practical route for smaller tactical activation

Programmatic

- Supports broad, cross-publisher planning
- Can centralize media buying across platforms
- May provide broader frequency and inventory management
- Supports existing enterprise buying and measurement arrangements

Microsoft Audience Ads connect Microsoft-specific intent, audience and remarketing signals with Search and Performance Max.

A demand-side platform (DSP) supports broader media buying. The two approaches can complement each other.

Blueprint session output: one page per advertiser, completed in the session

Duplicate this slide for each advertiser and complete every field before the session closes.

ADVERTISER AND ACCOUNT Complete in session	VERTICAL Complete in session	PRIMARY BUSINESS GOAL Complete in session	CURRENT BUILD AND GAP What is live, and what is missing?
MAIN BLOCKER Complete in session	RECOMMENDED CAMPAIGN BUILD Next campaign-level build, e.g. feed-based PMax	FIRST EXECUTION TASK Small, concrete task, e.g. collect approved assets	REQUIRED DATA, TRACKING, FEED, OR ASSETS List needs, access gaps and dependency owners
OWNER Named person accountable for the first task	TARGET LAUNCH TIMING Complete in session	REVIEW TIMING Date, KPI and minimum evidence to review	PRIMARY KPIS Target CPA/ROAS and agreed evidence threshold
ESTIMATED OPPORTUNITY OR EXPECTED COMMERCIAL OUTCOME Complete in session	STATUS Complete in session	Status options Not started / In progress / Blocked / Live	

The 30-day review: what to check, and what it triggers

Review the always-on build on a repeating thirty-day cycle, and let the evidence decide the next move.

CHECK

What to look at

- Is the stage live and stable, or still learning?
- Conversion and value data still flowing and accurate
- Performance against the measures agreed before launch
- Audience list sizes, creative fatigue, and budget pacing

OUTCOME 1

Advance a stage

- Current stage measured, stable, and hitting the agreed measure
- Tracking and feed clean enough for the next layer
- Budget available without cutting what already works
- Move to the next stage and set the next review date

OUTCOME 2

Hold and optimise

- Still inside the learning period or volume is thin
- Signal is right but creative or assets are limiting delivery
- Optimise inside the current stage rather than adding a layer
- Keep everything live: holding is not switching off

OUTCOME 3

Fix or escalate

- Tracking, feed, consent, or policy issue found
- Automation optimising toward a weak or unqualified action
- Work the diagnostic in order before changing the build
- Re-owner the blocker with a named date

Three outcomes only: advance, hold and optimise, or fix and escalate. Holding still means the account stays always-on.

Five points to take into every account conversation

The next logical step beats the most complete plan.

1

Start with the advertiser business goal, not the product

2

Protect the Search or Shopping activity that already works

3

Use Performance Max to automate and scale conversion

4

Use Audience Ads to create demand, control targeting, and build remarketing pools

5

Build to always-on: keep every proven layer live and move each recommendation into an owned activation and measurement plan

The right always-on build is not the most complex one. It is the next logical account step that can be implemented, measured, and kept running.

Troubleshooting 101: Audience Ads & Performance Max



Vertical pitfalls: the trap to check first in each vertical

Before the generic diagnostic, rule out the failure mode that is specific to the advertiser's vertical.

Travel

Seasonality and lead times judged on short CPA windows; booking value ignored.

Retail and ecommerce

Feed errors and product disapprovals cap delivery before bidding is ever the issue.

B2B

Automating against unqualified form fills instead of sales-accepted leads.

Careers and education

Enquiry volume counted as success when applications and enrolments are the goal.

Health and wellness

Policy restrictions and capacity limits hit before scale; sensitive targeting blocked.

Financial services

Approved volume, not application volume, is the outcome; compliance limits creative.

Gambling and betting

Certification and geo rules differ by market; sign-ups overstate value without deposits.

Dating

Free sign-ups flatter results; creative fatigues fast in a crowded category.

Automotive

Six-month purchase cycles measured in 30-day windows; dealer and OEM bid overlap.

Real estate and property

Broad geo wastes spend; listing inventory changes faster than the creative.

Home services and local trades

Untracked or missed calls make a working account look broken; capacity caps scale.

SaaS and technology

Trial volume without activation; no offline pipeline import on long cycles.

Takeaway: Rule out the vertical-specific pitfall first, then work the six checks in order.

If you see this, do this: the first move for the most common issues

Work the first step before changing structure, budget, or bidding.

IF YOU SEE THIS	POSSIBLE CAUSE	DO THIS FIRST	GUARDRAIL / INTERPRETATION
PMax spends but conversions drop	Tracking, conversion lag, weaker traffic or a change in offer/demand	Verify tracking. If sound, compare lag-adjusted results, traffic mix, feed and landing-page changes.	Avoid reacting to incomplete conversion data. Test one evidence-led fix.
PMax cannibalises Brand Search	No brand exclusion and overlapping intent	Apply brand exclusions and keep Brand Search live	Blended CPA mixes brand and non-brand. Check each separately and compare total account conversions.
Audience Ads deliver clicks, no sales	Mixed audiences, weak traffic quality, poor offer or landing-page friction	Separate prospecting/remarketing. If already split, review placements and test offer or page friction.	Keep the sales/CPA target. Use assisted outcomes as context, not proof of incremental sales.
Audience Ads barely deliver	Audience too narrow, budget too thin or manual bids too low	Check bid competitiveness (e.g. a 0.03 bid), budget and audience reach. Adjust one constraint.	Do not stack every targeting layer at once
Search campaign loses traffic to PMax after launch	Overlapping brand intent or budget diverted from proven Search	Check brand overlap, exclusions and Search budget. Compare total account conversions.	Distinguish traffic redistribution from a fall in market demand.

Audience Ads: the five issues that come up first

Most Audience Ads problems are targeting width, list health, or the wrong success measure.

AUDIENCE ADS ISSUE	DO THIS FIRST	THEN DO THIS	JUDGE IT BY
Low impressions or slow delivery	Check low manual bids, narrow targeting and budget limits. Adjust one constraint.	Add image, native and video formats for more inventory	Impressions, reach, delivery pacing
Clicks with no conversions	Verify tracking and conversion lag. Separate prospecting and remarketing if mixed.	If already split, audit placements, traffic quality, offer and landing-page friction. Test one fix.	Sales, conversion rate and CPA against target, with assisted outcomes as context
CPA looks far worse than Search	Compare like-for-like goals and lag. Test a separate remarketing campaign for qualified visitors.	Improve offer, creative and page conversion. Reallocate spend if CPA stays above target.	Agreed CPA and qualified sales. Assisted reporting adds context, not an exemption.
Remarketing lists too small	Check UET, consent, list rules and membership windows. Broaden only where relevant.	Build IBR from Audience impressions. Once eligible, activate in dedicated Audience remarketing.	Eligible list size, unique reach and frequency. IBR does not guarantee incremental reach.
Creative fatigue after a few weeks	Refresh images and headlines, keep the offer stable	Sequence messages from education to proof to offer	CTR trend and frequency

Performance Max: the five issues that come up first

Data readiness and one change at a time solve most Performance Max problems.

PERFORMANCE MAX ISSUE	DO THIS FIRST	THEN DO THIS	JUDGE IT BY
Campaign will not leave learning	Not enough conversion evidence in the goal	Consolidate asset groups and use a broader conversion goal	Weekly conversions, stability after 30 days
Retail delivery capped	Feed errors or Merchant Center disapprovals	Fix feed and product disapprovals before anything else	Approved product share, impressions
Spend concentrated on brand traffic	No brand exclusions applied	Add brand exclusions and keep Brand Search protected	Non-brand conversions and new customers
Volume drops after adding a target	ROAS or CPA target set too restrictive	Loosen the target, change one element at a time	Conversion volume at stable efficiency
Reporting does not explain performance	Review search-term insights, asset groups and product performance where available.	Set a weekly report by goal, brand/non-brand and change history. Flag reporting gaps.	Spend, qualified conversions, CPA/ROAS and documented causes of change

Budget pacing: when the campaign spends too early

Even hourly spend cannot be guaranteed. Auction opportunities, demand, competition and bidding affect delivery.

CHECK	WHAT MAY CONCENTRATE SPEND	RECOMMENDED ACTION	REVIEW AFTER THE CHANGE
Budget versus demand	Eligible traffic exceeds the available budget during busy periods.	Add budget headroom if affordable. Otherwise prioritize the highest-value traffic.	Spend by hour, daily exhaustion time and qualified outcomes
Bidding targets	Very low tCPA or very high tROAS may affect delivery and spend distribution.	Review targets against recent lag-adjusted results. Test one realistic adjustment.	Pacing alongside CPA/ROAS, allowing for conversion lag
Audience, geo and schedule	Restrictive audiences, keywords, locations or hours concentrate opportunities.	Broaden one constraint where business coverage and policy allow.	Eligible reach and hourly delivery, without sacrificing lead quality
Allocation and demand shifts	Overlapping campaigns, promotions, seasonality or competitors change demand.	Review budget allocation across campaigns. Prioritize objectives and plan for demand peaks.	Spend versus plan, overlap and total account outcomes
Conversion signals	Thin primary conversion volume limits the evidence available to automated bidding.	Add meaningful conversion actions only when they reflect value. Retain qualified primary goals.	Signal volume, lead quality and business results, not easy micro-conversions

Having an issue? Work these six checks in order

Use this before you rebuild anything in Audience Ads or Performance Max.

1 Is UET firing and are conversions correct?

2 Is Brand Search protected and excluded from PMax?

3 Is there enough conversion volume to learn?

4 Are targets, budgets, and audiences too narrow?

5 Are assets, feed, and landing pages complete?

6 Are you measuring upper funnel on the right KPI?

THEN TAKE ONE ACTION

Fix the data first

Tracking, feed, exclusions, and landing pages before any new campaign.

Give it room

Loosen targets, widen one signal, hold a stable two-week test.

Split and scale

Separate prospecting from remarketing, then scale only what is proven.

Common pitfall

Audience Ads and Performance Max are judged on last-click CPA against Brand Search. Use assisted conversions, view-through, and total account outcomes instead.

Five rules when building beyond Search

Simple habits that prevent most Audience and Performance Max problems.

1

Fix tracking, feed, and exclusions before launching anything new

2

Fund new builds with new budget, never from proven Search

3

Separate prospecting from remarketing so results stay readable

4

Change one material element at a time, then wait two weeks

5

Measure demand creation on assisted and total outcomes, not Brand CPA

If you see a problem, check the data first, give the change room to learn, and only then rebuild.

Peak-season sequencing model: what to run, and when

